the proliferation of monastic orders, their rules and practices, and their manifest impact on the reform of the Church between the tenth and twelfth centuries, the rules followed within various monasteries were rationalised in the interest of uniformity and preserving the rigour of the process of conversion for reformation.

The next phase was the division of the spiritual realm between the monks and the priests of the Church since monastic orders had not fully merged with the Church. However, the influence of the monastic orders on the Church led to the morphing of priesthood to mirror the rigours of a monastic life, which involved the four-stage process of vocation, reform, conversion and purification. Since monks and their way of life were exemplified as truly Christian by the Church, a hierarchy of sorts was created among the subjects of God, with monks occupying the top position followed by the clergy, the 'earthly secular' rulers and finally, the laity (lay believers). The order was a function of submission to God—the greater and more complete the submission, the greater the freedom from earthly authority and the higher the station occupied on earth as well as in the next world. Critically, there was an allocation of worlds between the monks and the clergy; the monks would lead the rest of the 'flock' in the other world, the Church and its clergy would lead the flock, including the rulers, in the earthly world akin to shepherds.[9] In effect, the priests became conduits to salvation and God since they were the true servants of God. This is the essence of the Christian doctrine *extra ecclesiam nulla salus*—all salvation is through Christ and Christ can be reached only through the Church, and therefore there is no salvation outside the Church.

Given its penultimate station in the spiritual hierarchy in the earthly world, the Church was regarded as the 'soul', while kings were the 'body'. Naturally, the Church, the soul which was deemed superior to the body, took it upon itself to preserve order in the earthly world and assumed an advisory role to the body, that is, the earthly rulers, on all matters both religious and secular. This effectively turned Christianity into a religion of the priests and the entirety of Christendom into the fiefdom of the Church, which freed the Church from the scrutiny of any form of earthly authority, and secured for it overlordship over earthly authority. The other less lofty objective was to secure complete proprietorial ownership of the Church, which was the property of the temporal rulers/kings until the eleventh century.